Unit 14: The End of the Beginning (One-Act Play)

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. In what ways does the play critique traditional gender roles, especially concerning domestic work?

• The play critiques traditional gender roles by showing that domestic work is skilled, demanding labour that requires experience, organisation, and physical stamina. Darry believes housework is simple and that he can do it better than Lizzie, but his every attempt ends in disaster.

• Lizzie, by contrast, manages both domestic and farm duties with efficiency. She feeds the animals, cooks, washes, irons, and sews — and still has energy to mow the meadow.

• The play thus challenges the stereotype that housework is easy or "women's work" that any man can master in an evening. Skill is determined by experience, not gender.

Q2. Do you think the play suggests that certain tasks are gender-specific, or does it emphasise the importance of experience? Explain your answer.

• The play does not suggest that tasks are gender-specific. It emphasises the importance of experience. Darry fails not because he is a man, but because he has never done the work and underestimates it.

• Lizzie succeeds because she has years of practice. Her skill is the product of experience.

• The message is that anyone — man or woman — who has not done domestic work will fail at it. The play attacks arrogance and ignorance, not masculinity.

Q3. How does Darry's overconfidence serve as a source of humour for the audience? What might the playwright be trying to teach about pride and humility?

• Darry's overconfidence creates humour through dramatic irony: the audience sees the disasters coming while Darry remains certain he will succeed. He boasts that he would do the housework "three times over," yet he cannot put on an overall, wind a clock, or wash a jug without breaking it.

• Every task escalates the comedy — the clock spring, the gramophone exercises, the broken jug, the bleeding nose, the razor-blades, the broken window, the heifer on the rope, the empty oil drum, and finally Darry himself up the chimney.

• The playwright teaches that pride comes before a fall. Darry's arrogance is punished by reality, and the audience learns that humility — respecting work you have never done — is wiser than boasting.

Q4. Do you think the farcical elements of the play are effective in conveying a deeper message? Why or why not?

• Yes, the farce is effective because the exaggerated disasters make the message memorable. The audience laughs at Darry, but the laughter carries a serious point: domestic work is real work.

• Farce uses exaggerated situations and clumsy mistakes to deliver a serious message in an entertaining manner.

• The comedy also makes the play accessible to a wide audience. A lecture on gender roles would be dull; a farce about a man up a chimney teaches the same lesson through laughter.

Q5. The play uses humour to say something serious. Do you agree that comedy is an effective medium for raising social issues? Why or why not?

• Yes, comedy is an effective medium because it reaches audiences that serious writing cannot. People who would resist a lecture will laugh at Darry and absorb the lesson.

• Humour also lowers defences: the audience laughs at Darry's pride, but in laughing, it recognises its own similar attitudes.

• O'Casey proves the point — the play is funny, but its message about respecting domestic work stays with the audience long after the laughter.

Q6. How might the play's themes be relevant to contemporary audiences? Are the issues raised still present in today's society?

• The issues are still present. In many societies, domestic work is still undervalued and taken for granted, and men still underestimate it.

• The play also speaks to modern debates about sharing household labour. Its message that skill comes from experience, not gender, supports the idea that partners should share domestic work.

• Darry's character is recognisable in any age: the person who criticises work he has never done.

Q7. What role does Barry play? How does he contribute to the plot and character development?

• Barry is Darry's well-meaning but inept friend. He contributes to the plot by making every situation worse: he puts the gramophone to "Fast," knocks the jug off the table, breaks the window, nearly cuts his fingers off, and climbs the shelves that crash down on him.

• He also serves as a comic mirror of Darry. Both men are useless at housework, and their arguments show two overconfident men blaming each other.

• Barry's presence shows that Darry's problem is not unique — it is the attitude of men who have never done domestic work. His spectacles, which he loses, symbolise his inability to "see" the work in front of him.

Q8. What is the significance of Darry's many failures in the play?

• Darry's failures are the play's argument made visible. Each failure — the clock, the exercises, the jug, the nose, the window, the bulb, the oil — proves Lizzie's claim that housework requires skill and experience.

• The failures also show the consequences of pride. Darry challenged Lizzie to prove housework was easy; the play proves the opposite, task by task.

• Finally, the failures create the farcical structure of the play. Without them, there would be no comedy and no message. Darry's final appearance — sooty, crawling from the fireplace — is the visual summary of his defeat.

Exercise B — Choose the Correct Option (Answer Key)

No.	Question	Answer
1	What task does Darry fail to do in the play?	c. complete the household chores
2	What is the primary theme explored in the play?	b. gender roles and stereotypes in domestic life
3	How does Darry feel about doing the housework before he attempts it?	b. confident
4	Which literary technique is primarily used in the play to highlight the absurdity of Darry's attempts?	a. farce
5	What lesson does Darry learn by the end of the play?	b. to respect the work Lizzie does

Vocabulary Exercises (Answers)

• **Guess and check (model):** slaughter — the act of killing brutally (Darry: "Half slaughtering myself for your sake!"). clasp — to hold tightly with both hands. handicap — a disadvantage that makes something difficult. plunge — to fall or push suddenly into something. shove — to push roughly.

Grammar — Types of Sentences (Answers)

No.	Sentence	Type
1	I can fix this easily.	Declarative
2	Can you help me with this?	Interrogative
3	Please don't touch that.	Imperative
4	Hurray! We did it perfectly!	Exclamatory
5	I don't think this will work.	Declarative
6	Why are you laughing?	Interrogative
7	Be careful with the glass.	Imperative
8	Wow! That's amazing!	Exclamatory
9	Pass me the book, please.	Imperative

Writing Tasks — Model Answers

A. Editing and Proofreading (Corrected Paragraph)

Ali loves playing football with his friends. They often play at the park near their house. Last Saturday, they decided to play a match against another team. However, when they arrived, the ground was crowded, so they had to wait. Finally, they got the chance to play, but it started to rain heavily. Ali slipped and fell, but his friends helped him up. Despite the rain, they continued playing and enjoyed the game. It was an exciting experience for all of them.

B. Dialogue Writing (Model — "The House in Chaos")

• **Setting:** [Inside Darry's cottage. Broken crockery lies scattered, a chair wobbles, and soapy water seeps across the floor. Darry stands in the middle, wiping sweat from his brow. Barry leans against the wall, grinning, a feather duster as his sceptre. The door creaks open — Lizzie's shadow appears.]

• **Darry:** [startled] Lizzie! You're back early!

• **Lizzie:** [looking around] Early? The meadow is mown, the heifer is safe, and I find the house looking like a battlefield. What happened here?

• **Barry:** [grinning] Nothing much, Lizzie. Only a jug, a window, a shelf, and Darry's nose.

• **Darry:** [indignantly] It was Barry's fault! He broke the jug, the window, and nearly cut his fingers off!

• **Barry:** [hotly] And who put the gramophone on "Fast," Darry? And who went up the chimney?

• **Lizzie:** [calmly] So the housework is done, is it? The delf is washed, the cowhouse is cleaned, and the heifer is stabled?

• **Darry:** [after a pause] Well... not exactly. But I've learned my lesson.

• **Lizzie:** [smiling] And what lesson is that?

• **Darry:** [sighing] That I'll never challenge you to change places again. The work of a house is done quietly, with speed, and without a whisper — and it takes a woman who knows how.

• **Lizzie:** [laughing] Now you see the result of having your own way. Come, both of you — I'll show you how the work of a house is done.

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